

U.S. HISTORY HACK™

Teacher Graphic Organizer Toolkit

Unit 8 — Postwar America (1945–1963) • Reproducible

WHY THIS TOOLKIT

Knowing WHICH organizer to use, and WHEN, is half the battle. This toolkit tells you — with a brief why for each — then gives you reproducible blanks (Part 1) and per-standard Cornell support backs (Part 2). Tennessee connections are highlighted throughout; the local-to-national move is a HistoryHack signature and a point of difference for our classrooms.

Which Organizer, When — Quick Guide

Scan the left column for what the activity asks students to do; reach for the organizer on the right. Every organizer in Part 1 also carries its own “when to use · why it works” note.

When the task asks students to...	Reach for...	Why it works
compare / contrast TWO things	Venn (2) or T-Chart	Marzano's highest-yield strategy; the overlap names shared traits
compare 3+ things on set criteria	Compare & Contrast Matrix	systematic; lowers cognitive load
explain causes / effects	Cause & Effect	makes causal chains visible (SSP.05)
put events in order / show change	Timeline / Sequence	builds chronological reasoning (SSP.05)
brainstorm or connect ideas	Concept Web	activates prior knowledge; shows relationships
summarize a text or source	Main Idea & Details	separates the central idea from support
activate prior knowledge & track learning	KWL	metacognition; frames inquiry
learn a key term deeply	Frayer	deep vocabulary processing
analyze a primary source	HIPPO / OPTIC	disciplinary sourcing (SSP.01–02)
make and defend a claim	CER	claim + evidence + reasoning (SSP.04)
weigh two sides / a decision	T-Chart or Problem–Solution	structures evaluation
capture the basics of an event	5 Ws	ensures full coverage
connect a national event to Tennessee	★ Tennessee Connection	our signature local-to-national move

Reproducible — you may copy these pages for classroom use.

Part 1 — Reusable Blank Organizers (all subjects, all units)

Content-agnostic blanks. Print as many as you need; use across any standard or subject.

Task says “compare,” “contrast,” “how are they alike/different?” for TWO things. Marzano’s #1 strategy (identifying similarities & differences). The shared column forces students to name what overlaps, not just list traits.

[illegible]

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one

factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Venn (3) / Triple T-Chart — Compare THREE

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Comparing three people, groups, or ideas. Use the columns for each item and note shared traits in your notes.

Item A	Item B	Item C
Trait / criterion 1		
Trait / criterion 2		
Trait / criterion 3		
Trait / criterion 4		

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Two categories to sort or weigh: benefits vs costs, pros vs cons, before vs after, cause vs effect. Fast, low-floor entry point for comparison.

[illegible]

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Compare & Contrast Matrix — Items × Criteria

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Comparing several items across the SAME set of criteria. Reduces cognitive load by making the comparison systematic.

Criterion	Item 1	Item 2	Item 3

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Cause & Effect — Causal Chains

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Task asks “what caused...?”, “what were the effects/consequences of...?” Makes causal reasoning visible (builds SSP.05).

Cause	→	Effect
	→	
	→	
	→	
	→	

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Activating prior knowledge or showing how ideas relate to a central concept. Great as a pre-reading or review move.

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Start of a standard: what students Know / Want to know; end: what they Learned. Builds metacognition and frames inquiry.

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

5 Ws — Cover the Basics of an Event

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS Making sure students capture who/what/when/where/why of an event before analysis.	
Question	Answer
Who?	
What?	
When?	
Where?	
Why?	
MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS) Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first. Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?” Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice). Sentence frame: “ _____ because _____, which shows _____.”	

Framer Model — Deep Vocabulary

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Learning a key term deeply (definition, characteristics, examples, non-examples).

Definition (own words)	Characteristics

Examples	Non-examples

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

CER — Build an Argument

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Any “make a claim / defend / argue” task. Claim + two pieces of evidence + reasoning (builds SSP.04).

Part	Write here
Claim	
Evidence (two specifics)	
Reasoning	

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

HIPPO — Analyze a Primary Source

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Analyzing a photo, cartoon, map, or document (builds SSP.01–SSP.02). Pair with OPTIC for visuals.

H-I-P-P-O	Prompt / notes
H — Historical context	
I — Intended audience	
P — Purpose	
P — Point of view	
O — Outside connection	

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

★ Tennessee Connection — Local ↔ National

WHEN TO USE • WHY IT WORKS

Whenever a standard has a Tennessee tie: link the national event to our state/community and say why the local story matters. This local-to-national move is a HistoryHack signature — use it often.

[illegible]

MAKE IT WORK FOR EVERY STUDENT (UDL • MTSS)

Scaffold — offer a sentence starter or a small word bank, or let students complete part of the organizer with a partner first.

Extend — push higher-DOK: “Which side has the stronger case, and why?” or “What would change if one factor were different?”

Show it your way — students may write, say it aloud, draw/label, or build it (UDL response choice).

Sentence frame: “_____ because _____, which shows _____.”

Part 2 — Cornell Support Backs (per standard, reproducible)

Guided and Light scaffolds for each standard's Cornell notes — moved here from the student workbook so you copy them only as needed (MTSS). Fade Guided → Light → independent as evidence grows.

US.71 — 1950s Prosperity & Consumerism: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
White-Collar Jobs	Professional, managerial, and clerical jobs that grew dramatically in the 1950s as the U.S. economy shifted from manufacturing to service industries. Workers in these jobs typically wore white dress shirts to offices rather than blue work shirts to factories.
Suburban Ideal	The 1950s American dream of owning a single-family home in the suburbs with a yard, garage, and modern appliances. Suburbs like Levittown offered affordable housing for middle-class families leaving cities.
G.I. Bill	The Servicemen's Readjustment Act of 1944 that provided veterans with benefits including college tuition, low-cost mortgages, and unemployment insurance. It helped millions of WWII veterans buy homes and get education, fueling 1950s prosperity.

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of 1950s prosperity & consumerism was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of 1950s prosperity & consumerism was White-Collar Jobs: Professional, managerial, and clerical jobs that grew dramatically in the 1950s as the U.S. economy shifted from manufacturing to service industries. Workers in these jobs typically wore white dress shirts to offices rather than blue work shirts to factories.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
White-Collar Jobs	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Suburban Ideal	
G.I. Bill	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Post-War Economic Boom” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Growth of White-Collar Jobs” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “The Suburban Ideal” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
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WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.72 — Baby Boomer Generation Impact: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Baby Boom	The dramatic increase in birth rates from 1946-1964, when 76 million babies were born. This generation transformed American economy and culture as they grew up, creating demand for schools, products, and services.
G.I. Bill	The Servicemen's Readjustment Act of 1944 that provided veterans with benefits including college tuition, low-cost mortgages, and unemployment insurance. It helped millions of WWII veterans buy homes and get education, fueling 1950s prosperity.
Causes of the Baby Boom	WWII veterans returning home; economic prosperity; G.I. Bill benefits; cultural emphasis on family; improved medical care

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of baby boomer generation impact was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of baby boomer generation impact was Baby Boom: The dramatic increase in birth rates from 1946-1964, when 76 million babies were born. This generation transformed American economy and culture as they grew up, creating demand for schools, products, and services.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Baby Boom	_____ _____
G.I. Bill	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Causes of the Baby Boom	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “What Was the Baby Boom?” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Reshaping the American Economy” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “New Markets and Industries” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
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WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.73 — Eisenhower Administration Developments: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Interstate Highway System	Massive network of highways authorized by President Eisenhower in 1956, covering 41,000 miles. Built for national defense and economic development, it transformed American travel, commerce, and settlement patterns.
Polio Vaccine	Dr. Jonas Salk's 1955 vaccine that virtually eliminated polio, a crippling disease that had terrorized American families. Mass vaccination campaigns made it one of the great medical triumphs of the 1950s.
Salk Polio Vaccine (1955)	Eliminated feared disease; 45,000+ cases/year before vaccine; restored confidence in medical science; children could safely attend schools

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of Eisenhower administration developments was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of Eisenhower administration developments was Interstate Highway System: Massive network of highways authorized by President Eisenhower in 1956, covering 41,000 miles. Built for national defense and economic development, it transformed American travel, commerce, and settlement patterns.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Interstate Highway System	_____ _____
Polio Vaccine	_____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Salk Polio Vaccine (1955)	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Medical Breakthroughs: The Polio Vaccine” section, and what evidence supports it?
- What is the main idea of the “Interstate Highway System: Economic Effects” section, and what evidence supports it?
- What is the main idea of the “Interstate Highway System: Social Effects” section, and what evidence supports it?
- Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?

WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?

Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.74 — Automobile's Growing Influence: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Fast Food Chains	Standardized restaurants offering quick, inexpensive meals that spread along highways in the 1950s. McDonald's, opened by Ray Kroc in 1955, became the symbol of this new industry.
Levittown	Pioneering planned suburban community built by William Levitt starting in 1947. Mass-produced affordable homes made homeownership accessible to middle-class families, becoming the model for suburban development.
Car Ownership Explosion	1945: 25M registered cars; 1960: 61M cars; average family owned car by 1960; symbol of freedom and prosperity

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of automobile's growing influence was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of automobile's growing influence was Fast Food Chains: Standardized restaurants offering quick, inexpensive meals that spread along highways in the 1950s. McDonald's, opened by Ray Kroc in 1955, became the symbol of this new industry.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — "This term means ..."
Fast Food Chains	_____ _____
Levittown	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Car Ownership Explosion	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Transforming American Daily Life” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Connection to Suburban Growth” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Fast Food and Hospitality Industries” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
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WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.75 — Television and Mass Media Impact: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Television	The dominant mass medium of the 1950s that transformed American home life, politics, and culture. TV ownership grew from 9% of homes in 1950 to 87% by 1960.
Mass Media	Forms of communication reaching large audiences, including television, radio, newspapers, and magazines. In the 1950s, mass media gained unprecedented influence over American opinions, politics, and purchasing habits.
Rapid TV Adoption	1950: 9% of homes had TV; 1960: 87% had TV; average viewing 5+ hours/day; replaced radio as center of home entertainment

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame One key cause/effect of television and mass media impact was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.	
Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ) A key idea of television and mass media impact was Television: The dominant mass medium of the 1950s that transformed American home life, politics, and culture. TV ownership grew from 9% of homes in 1950 to 87% by 1960.	
Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	
Evidence	
Explain	
Headline	

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Television	
Mass Media	

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Rapid TV Adoption	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “Television Changes Family Life” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Television and Politics” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Advertising and Consumer Culture” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
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WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.76 — Youth Culture and Tennessee Music: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
Beatniks	Members of the 1950s Beat Generation who rejected mainstream culture, materialism, and conformity. Writers like Jack Kerouac and Allen Ginsberg challenged conventional values.
Rock 'n' Roll	Revolutionary music genre emerging in the 1950s that combined rhythm and blues, country, and gospel. Elvis Presley became the "King of Rock 'n' Roll," representing youth rebellion and cultural change.
Elvis Presley	Tennessee singer who became "The King of Rock 'n' Roll" in the 1950s. His music, style, and performances revolutionized American popular culture and launched rock music as a global phenomenon.

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame One key cause/effect of youth culture and tennessee music was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.	
Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ) A key idea of youth culture and tennessee music was Beatniks: Members of the 1950s Beat Generation who rejected mainstream culture, materialism, and conformity. Writers like Jack Kerouac and Allen Ginsberg challenged conventional values.	
Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____ _____
Explain	_____ _____ _____
Headline	_____ _____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — "This term means ..."
Beatniks	_____ _____
Rock 'n' Roll	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
Elvis Presley	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “The Beat Generation” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Tennessee's Central Role in Music” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “Breaking Racial Barriers Through Music” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
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WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.

US.77 — Kennedy's New Frontier: Cornell Support Backs

Reproducible — scaffolds ONLY the Cornell notes for this standard. Copy for students who need them; fade as evidence grows. Not a track, not a separate grade.

Guided Support

Key vocabulary	What it means
New Frontier	President John F. Kennedy's 1960s domestic program promoting economic growth, education, civil rights, and space exploration. Represented optimism and progressive change.
Peace Corps	Volunteer program created by President Kennedy in 1961 sending Americans to developing countries to help with education, health, and economic development while promoting goodwill.
New Frontier Programs	Federal aid to education; civil rights enforcement; tax cuts for growth; increased minimum wage; Medicare proposal (passed later)

Break it into steps: 1) Name one cause or effect. 2) Give one piece of evidence. 3) Write one sentence explaining the link.

Sentence frame

One key cause/effect of Kennedy's New Frontier was _____, shown by _____, which mattered because _____.

Modeled example (one worked note — yours will differ)

A key idea of Kennedy's New Frontier was New Frontier: President John F. Kennedy's 1960s domestic program promoting economic growth, education, civil rights, and space exploration. Represented optimism and progressive change.

Step	Rehearse it here, then transfer to the Cornell front
Name it	_____ _____
Evidence	_____ _____
Explain	_____ _____
Headline	_____ _____

Light Support

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — "This term means ..."
New Frontier	_____ _____
Peace Corps	_____ _____

Key vocabulary	Finish the idea — “This term means ...”
New Frontier Programs	

Guiding questions — answer on the lines below or in your front notes:

- What is the main idea of the “New Frontier Goals” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “The Peace Corps” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - What is the main idea of the “The Space Race Priority” section, and what evidence supports it?
 - Whose perspective benefits in this passage, and whose is harmed or left out?
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WHICH CUE STILL NEEDS WORK?
Circle the Cornell cue you still need help with, and tell your teacher.